DIDI PLAYS THE DOLE DRUM PG 10

SUNIL BANSAL: MAN ON A MISSION PG 13

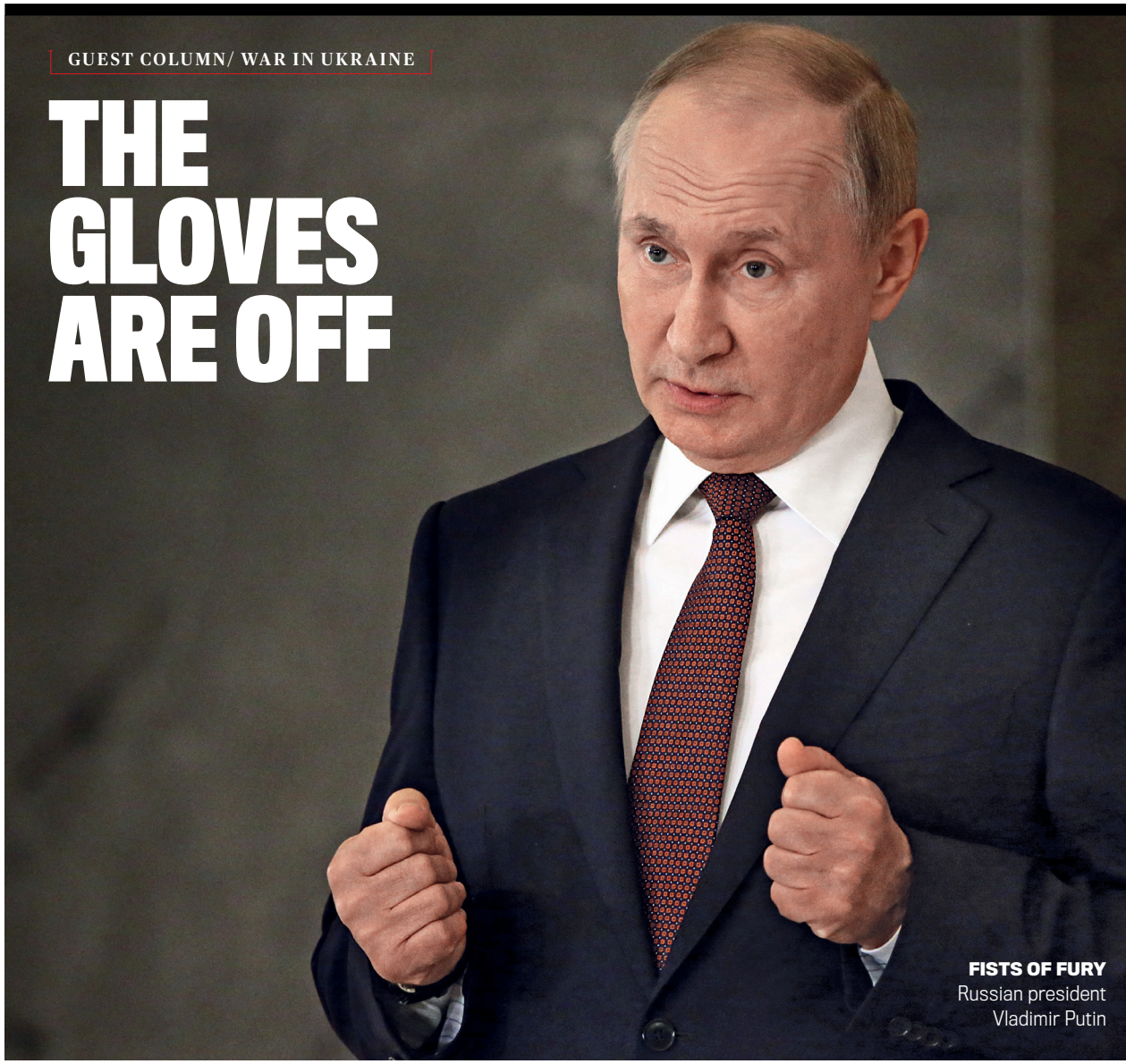
UPFRONT

A DANGEROUS HIGH IN KERALA PG 12

THE NEW POWER CORRIDOR PG 16

GUEST COLUMN/ WAR IN UKRAINE

THE GLOVES ARE OFF



FISTS OF FURY Russian president Vladimir Putin

Photographs by GETTY IMAGES



By PANKAJ SARAN

The Russian "special military operation" in Ukraine has now completed its seventh month. The pithiest comment to capture the mood in the "rest" of the world is the one made by Dr S. Jaishankar when he said recently, echoing Nehru: "Europe has to get over its belief that its problems are the world's problems, but the world's problems are not its." Sitting a few thousand miles away, India, like the majority of the world, is watching the power struggle under way in Europe, with grave consequences to its economy.

After seven months of tactical feints, localised battles and significant military losses, the areas of Russian interest in Ukraine have become clearer. These are the eastern periphery of Ukraine bordering Russia, the core being the Donets Basin, or Donbass for short, and some parts of Ukraine bordering the Black Sea, near Crimea. Many of these have large ethnic Rus-